

Photosensitive Drugs

80.3 Links in PDF documents are not guaranteed to work. To follow a web link, please use the MCD Website.

Tracking Information

Publication Number

100-3

Manual Section Number

80.3

Manual Section Title

Photosensitive Drugs

Version Number

3

Effective Date of this Version

04/03/2013

Implementation Date

07/16/2013

Description Information

Benefit Category

Drugs and Biologicals

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Item/Service Description

Photosensitive drugs are the light-sensitive agents used in photodynamic therapy. Once introduced into the body, these drugs selectively identify and adhere to diseased tissue. The drugs remain inactive until they are exposed to a specific wavelength of light, by means of a laser, that corresponds to their absorption peak. The activation of a photosensitive drug results in a photochemical reaction which treats the diseased tissue without affecting surrounding normal tissue.

Verteporfin

Verteporfin, a benzoporphyrin derivative, is an intravenous lipophilic photosensitive drug with an absorption peak of 690 nm. This drug was first approved by the Food and Drug Administration on April 12, 2000, and subsequently, approved for inclusion in the United

States Pharmacopoeia on July 18, 2000, meeting Medicare's definition of a drug when used in conjunction with ocular photodynamic therapy (OPT) (see section [80.2](#), "Photodynamic Therapy") when furnished intravenously incident to a physician's service. For patients with age-related macular degeneration (AMD), verteporfin is only covered with a diagnosis of neovascular AMD with predominately classic subfoveal choroidal neovascular (CNV) lesions (where the area of classic CNV occupies $\geq 50\%$ of the area of the entire lesion) at the initial visit as determined by a fluorescein angiogram (FA). Subsequent follow-up visits will require either an optical coherence tomography or an FA to assess treatment response. OPT with verteporfin is covered for the above indication and will remain non-covered for all other indications related to AMD (see section [80.2](#)). OPT with verteporfin for use in non-AMD conditions is eligible for coverage through individual Medicare Administrative Contractor discretion.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

Cross Reference

See NCD on Ocular Photodynamic Therapy [§80.2](#).

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

155

Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/Regulations-and-Guidance/Guidance/Transmittals/Downloads/R155NCD.pdf>

Revision History

03/2025 - The purpose of this Change Request (CR) is to provide a quarterly maintenance update of ICD-10 coding conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). No policy is being changed as a result of these updates. ([TN 13097](#)) (CR13939)

10/2024 - The purpose of the Change Request (CR) is to provide a quarterly maintenance update of ICD-10 coding conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). No policy is being changed as a result of these updates. ([TN 12903](#)) (CR13818)

01/2018 - This Change Request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of International Code of Diseases, Tenth Revision (ICD-10) conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates that can be found at: <https://www.cms.gov/Medicare/Coverage/CoverageGenInfo/ICD10.html>, along with other CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to

NCDs will be included in subsequent quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. ([TN 2005](#)) (CR10318)

11/2017 - This Change Request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of International Code of Diseases, Tenth Revision (ICD-10) conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received. ([TN 1975](#)) (CR10318)

05/2017 - This change request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions and other coding updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates that can be found at: <https://www.cms.gov/Medicare/Coverage/CoverageGenInfo/ICD10.html>, along with other CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent, quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. ([TN 1854](#)) (CR10086)

02/2017 - This change request (CR) is the 10th maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions and other coding updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates as follows: CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, CR9087, CR9252, CR9540, CR9631, and CR9751, as well as in CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent, quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. ([TN 1792](#)) (CR9861)

12/2015 - This change request (CR) is the 3rd maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions/updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, & CR9087. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately that included ICD-10 coding. Implementation date: 01/04/2016 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1580](#)) (CR9252)

08/2015 - This change request (CR) is the 3rd maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions/updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, & CR9087. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately that included ICD-10 coding.

These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/04/2016 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1537](#)) (CR 9252)

05/2014 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 10/06/2014 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1388](#)) ([TN 1388](#)) (CR 8691)

09/2012 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/07/2013 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1122](#)) ([TN 1122](#)) (CR 7818)

06/2013 - Effective for claims with dates of service on and after April 3, 2013, CMS expanded coverage of ocular photodynamic therapy (OPT) with verteporfin for "wet" age-related macular degeneration (AMD) in NCD 80.3.1, Verteporfin. CMS revised the requirements for testing to permit either optical coherence tomography (OCT) or fluorescein angiography (FA) to assess treatment response. Corresponding changes are referenced in NCDs 80.3 - Photosensitive Drugs, 80.2 - Photodynamic Therapy, and 80.2.1 - Ocular Photodynamic Therapy (OPT). Effective date: 04/03/2013 and implementation date: 07/16/2013. ([TN 155](#)) (CR 8292)

04/2004 - Covered for subfoveal occult with no classic CNV associated with AMD; and subfoveal minimally classic CNV (where area of classic CNV occupies <50% of area of entire lesion) associated with AMD, provided certain criteria met. Effective and implementation dates 04/01/2004. ([TN 9](#)) (CR 3191)

11/2002 - Deleted code reference for photosensitive drugs because it belongs in claims processing instructions. Effective and implementation dates 01/01/2003. ([TN 162](#)) (CR 2438)

08/2002 - Provided that Verteporfin when used with OPT for treatment of patients with AMD with occult and no classic lesions remained noncovered. Effective and implementation dates 08/20/2002. ([TN 157](#)) (CR 2335)

02/2001 - Included verteporfin for use in OPT for patients with neovascular AMD with predominately classic subfoveal CNV lesions (where the area of classic CNV occupies = 50% of area of entire lesion), as determined by a fluorescein angiogram. Effective and implementation dates 07/01/2001. ([TN 135](#)) (CR 1549)

National Coverage Analyses (NCAs)

This NCD has been or is currently being reviewed under the National Coverage Determination process. The following are existing associations with NCAs, from the National Coverage Analyses database.

- [Original Consideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066N\)](#)
- [First reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R\)](#)
- [Second reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R2\)](#)
- [Third reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R3\)](#)
- [Fourth reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy \(OPT\) with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R4\)](#)

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Photosensitive Drugs	3	04/03/2013 - N/A	You are here
Photosensitive Drugs	2	04/01/2004 - 04/03/2013	View
Photosensitive Drugs	1	01/01/2003 - 04/01/2004	View